tomorrow.' Irani met the private secretary who reportedly demanded Rs 4 crore to extend the lease. Irani refused saying, 'Tatas do not give money for approvals.' The private secretary told him, 'You talk to Tata.' Irani said that his answer would be no different, but the private secretary insisted. So Irani called up Ratan.

Ratan replied, 'Why have you called to ask me this? You know my answer on such issues. We do not make such payments.' The refusal was communicated, and the ministry withheld approval for 50 per cent of the area, leading to a loss of minerals worth around Rs 1,000 crore on account of Ratan's refusal to pay Rs 4 crore as a bribe. But 'that is Ratan Tata', said Irani.

It is not that the Tata Group has always ended up getting the wrong end of the stick for unflinchingly sticking to its policy of not making secret political contributions. How they managed the tricky political environment in Bihar is as interesting as it is educative. Irani recalled that they were able to succeed when they were upfront about their policies and did not make any distinction between parties or situations.

But when they found that even approvals for their routine proposals were not forthcoming from Patna, Irani called on Chief Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav on Ratan's advice. He had heard that the chief minister was not an easy person to deal with: he had a reputation for being 'imperious'.

Irani was forewarned that there could be a demand for political funding. Therefore, when he met the chief minister, he told him upfront that the chairman had instructed him to communicate that Tata Sons made no exception from the policy on political funding. Irani was not sure how Yadav would react. He quickly added that they could, however, undertake social welfare schemes and help build infrastructure in the state. In this manner, they would help the society and contribute to the development of the state without even taking credit for it.

It is the policy of the group to pay back to the society the profits the company makes, he added. According to Irani, Yadav just said, '*Theek hai* (Okay).' A befuddled Irani did not know what to make of this, but said that 'from that day onwards, no unreasonable demands were made on the group'.

The Tatas stuck to their side of the bargain. Irani said that during the winter months, Tata Steel gave blankets to all prisoners in Patna's jail, without any Tata insignia or emblem on them. This pleased the chief